

AMERICA DRAWN INTO VIETNAM

MARCH 1959–December 1964

From 1959, the North Vietnamese leadership decided to back a guerrilla uprising among the rural population of South Vietnam, who resented the rule of President Ngo Dinh Diem. The Ho Chi Minh Trail was created to carry military supplies from the North to guerrillas in the South. Fearing the spread of communism in Asia, the United States supported a South Vietnamese counterinsurgency campaign, sending in military advisers, including the Green Berets. In 1963, with Diem's regime losing the guerrilla war and facing protests by Vietnamese Buddhists and chaos on the streets, America backed a military coup in which Diem was killed. The following year, the Tonkin Gulf Incident, a naval clash off North Vietnam, won US Congressional authorization for an open-ended escalation of US military involvement in Vietnam.